

THE FREE SIGNUP GIFT · THE WEEKLY ONE-SHOT

THE DM'S FIELD KIT

Seven tables you can reach for at any table, in any fantasy game. Plus the d100 you already have.

Long Island Dungeon Master · system-agnostic · 5e-compatible

Here's the thing nobody tells you when you start running games: the prep is never the problem. The problem is the moment the party does something you didn't write down, and four people are looking at you, and the silence is getting expensive.

This kit is for that silence. Seven tables you keep open in a tab or print on a few sheets, built so you can roll once and have something true to say in the next five seconds. No theme, no setting, no system to learn. They drop into whatever game you're already running.

A real person made these. Thirty years behind the screen, a lot of bad nights and a few good ones, and zero machine slop. Every row had to earn its place: if it was just decoration, I cut it and wrote one that hands the players a decision instead. You'll feel the difference at the table, which is the only place any of this counts.

Seven tables below. The eighth — the d100 **What the Villain Is Doing Right Now** — is the centerpiece, and it's already in your welcome email. Between them they cover the whole session: who the people are and what they actually want, the tic you'll remember them by, the room, the loot, the town that's already on edge when you ride in, and the worst roll of the night.

1. THIS NPC IS NOT WHO THEY SEEM

Roll when the party leans on a "minor" NPC harder than you planned — and you need that NPC to have a second floor under the first.

Most NPCs are exactly what they look like. The interesting ones aren't. Each row gives you who they seem to be, who they actually are, and the tell — the one detail a careful player can catch before the reveal, so the twist feels earned instead of cheap. Drop the tell early. Pay it off later.

D20	SEEMS TO BE...	ACTUALLY IS...	THE TELL
1	A nervous shopkeep	The fence who moved the stolen goods, scared the party found him	Counts coins twice, won't take the marked one
2	A drunk at the bar	The only sober witness to the murder, drinking to forget the face	Flinches at the victim's name, not the noise
3	A grieving widow	The one who arranged the death and is now afraid she'll be caught grieving wrong	Cries on cue, eats with appetite
4	A helpful guide	Leading the party the long way to give his employer time to clear out	Knows shortcuts he never offers
5	A temple beggar	A disgraced priest who still hears confessions no one knows they're giving	Repeats your own words back, slightly cleaned up

D20	SEEMS TO BE...	ACTUALLY IS...	THE TELL
6	A loyal old servant	Skimming the estate for thirty years, now blackmailed by someone who noticed	Two sets of ledgers, one for show
7	A captured prisoner	The bait, planted to be rescued and walked straight into the camp	Wrists chafed, but the rope was tied loose
8	A wandering healer	Carrying the plague on purpose, paid to seed it town by town	Never gets sick, never stays long
9	A by-the-book guard captain	A man one bribe past the point of caring, waiting for the offer	Looks at the gate, not the threat
10	A simple farmer	The retired killer the party's been hunting, hoping the past stays buried	Hands too steady for the plow
11	A cheerful innkeeper	An informant who sells every guest's business by morning	Remembers names too well
12	A child lost in the market	The lookout, counting the party's purses for the crew down the alley	Not crying for a parent, watching the doors
13	A rival adventurer	A debtor who took a job to deliver the party, not to help them	Generous with drinks, vague about the patron
14	A pious pilgrim	Hauling something in the reliquary that should never have left its box	Won't set the case down, even to eat
15	A harmless fortune-teller	A blackmailer reading guilt off faces and selling silence	Her "visions" are last week's gossip
16	A devoted apprentice	The one who poisoned the master slowly, learning the trade in the meantime	Quotes the master in the past tense too soon
17	A town hero	The arsonist who set the fire so he could be the one who saved them	First on every scene, always
18	A frightened messenger	Carrying a sealed order to have the reader killed, and he knows it	Hands the letter over fast, won't make eye contact
19	A kindly stranger paying your tab	Recruiting for a debt the party won't know they signed until later	Generosity with no ask is the ask
20	Exactly who they seem	And the party will never believe it, which is its own problem	Nothing. That's the tell.

ROLL TWICE & COMBINE

Roll twice when you want layers: the first roll is the mask the party sees, the second is what's under it when they peel the first one back. (A "grieving widow" hiding a "retired killer" is a better villain than either alone.)



2. WHAT'S ACTUALLY IN THIS ROOM

Roll when the party opens a door you didn't detail, and "it's an empty room" would kill the momentum.

Dungeon dressing usually means furniture. This is dressing that hands the players a decision the second they walk in. Every row is a small fork: take it, use it, break it, or leave it and wonder. Read the bold thing aloud; keep the part after the dash for yourself.

D20 IN THE ROOM...

- 1 **A table set for a meal, food still warm** — someone left in the last minute and might be watching, or coming back
- 2 **A locked chest already pried open and empty** — someone beat the party here; the question is who, and where they went
- 3 **A wall of small doors, each with a different name carved above it** — one of the names belongs to a party member
- 4 **A well with a rope going down and a bucket coming up on its own** — something below is hauling, and it expects company
- 5 **A fire that gives no heat and casts the wrong shadows** — the shadows show what the room looked like a hundred years ago
- 6 **A child's room, dust-free in a building of dust** — someone cleans it; find out who, and you find out a lot
- 7 **A map of the dungeon on the wall with one room circled in red** — it's the room the party most wants to avoid, and now they know
- 8 **A pile of weapons, all bent the same direction** — whatever did that is still in the building
- 9 **A door warm to the touch with quiet voices behind it** — the voices stop the moment a hand touches the wood
- 10 **A statue holding a real, usable lever** — pulling it does something, somewhere, that the party won't see from here
- 11 **A floor of dried mud with one set of fresh tracks leading in and none leading out** — do the math
- 12 **A cage with the door open and the lock bitten through** — from the inside
- 13 **A shrine with fresh offerings and no congregation for miles** — somebody walks a long way to keep this fed
- 14 **A ledger left open mid-entry, the ink still wet** — the last line names someone the party knows
- 15 **A bed, slept in, and a second one never touched but kept ready** — for a guest who's expected and overdue
- 16 **A row of portraits with one face scratched out** — the same face, in every painting, no matter the body
- 17 **A pool of clear water with a key at the bottom, just out of arm's reach** — and the water's colder than water should be
- 18 **A trail of blood that's been mopped, badly, in a hurry** — leading to a wall with no door in it
- 19 **A music box still playing, winding itself when it slows** — it stops if anyone says the wrong name, and starts again at the right one
- 20 **A mirror reflecting a room that isn't this one** — and there's a way into that other room, if the party's foolish enough

ROLL TWICE & COMBINE

Roll twice for a room with a layer: the first roll is what they see, the second is what they find when they actually search it. (Warm food on the table, and the ledger underneath naming the cook.)



3. THE REWARD HAS A STORY

Roll when the party earns loot and you want it to mean something past the gold-piece value — a string attached, a door it opens, a problem it becomes.

Treasure with no story is just a number on a sheet. Every item here carries a hook: a consequence, a lead, or a person who wants it back. Hand it out freely. The hook does the work later.

D20 THE REWARD...

- | | |
|----|---|
| 1 | A purse of coin, every piece stamped with a face that's now illegal to carry |
| 2 | A fine sword with another family's crest, and that family is still looking for it |
| 3 | A signed letter of credit worth a fortune, drawn on a bank that just collapsed |
| 4 | A ring that opens one specific door somewhere, and someone wants to know who's wearing it |
| 5 | A map to a second cache, drawn by a hand that wanted whoever followed it to die |
| 6 | A jeweled holy symbol from a faith that punishes theft of its relics personally |
| 7 | A debt owed to the previous owner, now owed to whoever holds the marker — the party |
| 8 | A beautiful weapon that the last three owners all died holding; the smith remembers each one |
| 9 | A locked box the party can't open and shouldn't sell without knowing what's inside |
| 10 | A title deed to land the party has never seen, currently occupied by people who won't leave |
| 11 | A potion that works exactly once and is worth a kingdom to the right buyer, who is desperate |
| 12 | A masterwork tool stolen from a guild that brands thieves and has a long memory |
| 13 | A favor in writing from a powerful person, redeemable once, who has since changed sides |
| 14 | A child's toy worth nothing, that a very dangerous someone will pay anything to recover |
| 15 | A set of keys, no labels, and the nagging certainty that one of them matters |
| 16 | A trained animal that obeys its dead master's commands and no one else's, yet |
| 17 | A cloak that belonged to a wanted person; wearing it means wearing their face to those who knew them |
| 18 | A ledger of names, half of them crossed out, the survivors worth knowing or worth avoiding |
| 19 | A gem that's clearly a payment for something that hasn't happened yet, with a date inside |
| 20 | A perfectly ordinary, perfectly valuable hoard — and the rumor of it travels faster than the party does |

QUICK KEY

Rows 1–6 are loot that's *hot* (someone wants it back). Rows 7–14 are loot that's a *lead* (it points somewhere). Rows 15–20 are loot that's a *slow burn* (the problem shows up sessions later). Pick the timing your table needs.

4. FAIL FORWARD

Roll when a check fails and "nothing happens" would stall the whole night. The failed roll doesn't stop the story; it bends it.

The deadliest words at any table are “you don't find anything.” A failed roll should cost something or move something, never just end the turn. Roll on this when you're stuck for what a failure *does*. The party still doesn't get the clean win — they get a complication they have to deal with instead.

D12 INSTEAD OF NOTHING...

- 1 They succeed, but it takes far longer than they have, and something arrives in the meantime
- 2 They succeed, but loudly — whatever they were sneaking past now knows they're here
- 3 They get it wrong in a way that looks right, and won't learn the truth until it matters
- 4 They succeed, but it costs a resource: a broken tool, a spent charge, a torn map
- 5 They learn half of it — enough to act, not enough to be safe
- 6 Someone else solves it first, and now the party owes them
- 7 They succeed, but leave a trace that leads someone right to them later
- 8 The attempt works on a delay; it'll pay off at the worst possible moment
- 9 They hit a different problem they didn't know was there, and have to deal with that first
- 10 They succeed, but only one of them can carry it forward — who, and what gets left behind?
- 11 The information is true but planted; acting on it walks them into someone's plan
- 12 They succeed completely, and that's the trap — it was meant to be found

HOW TO USE IT WITHOUT IT GETTING SAMEY

Don't roll every failure. Save this for the rolls that *matter* — the locked door to the only exit, the negotiation the whole session hinged on. A clean failure is fine when the stakes are low. Pull this out when “nothing happens” would put four people on their phones.



S. MANNERISMS & TICS

Roll when an NPC needs to exist as a person five seconds after you invent them — give them one habit and the players will remember them all night.

A name is forgettable. A tic isn't. Hand an NPC one physical or verbal habit and the players will start calling them “the one who keeps cleaning his glasses” before they ever learn his name — and that's the NPC who survives the session in their memory. Some of these reveal something true about the person. Some are just texture. A few will make the table lean back. Grab one mid-sentence; you don't have to know why they do it yet.

D20 THE NPC...

- 1 Touches a scar when they lie, every time, and has no idea they do it
- 2 Never finishes their sentences, and somehow you always know how they end
- 3 Laughs half a beat too late, like they're waiting to be told it's funny
- 4 Cleans something that's already clean — a cup, a blade, the same spot on the table
- 5 Calls everyone by the wrong name on purpose, and gets yours exactly right once, to make a point
- 6 Answers a question with the question, buying the second they need to decide whether to lie
- 7 Keeps one hand on whatever they'd grab if this goes wrong
- 8 Smiles with the mouth only; the eyes are doing a different job
- 9 Counts on their fingers under the table when they think, and stops the instant they're watched
- 10 Repeats the last word you said, quietly, before they reply — tasting it
- 11 Won't sit with their back to a door, and rearranges the room to fix it without comment
- 12 Apologizes for things that aren't their fault and never for the things that are
- 13 Eats while they talk about something terrible, and stops eating when it gets personal
- 14 Picks at a wedding ring that isn't there anymore
- 15 Speaks to the most powerful person in the room even when answering someone else
- 16 Hums one tune, the same six notes, when the lying gets hard
- 17 Overshares one true thing early so the next ten lies go down easy
- 18 Watches your hands, not your face — a habit from a life they don't mention
- 19 Goes very still when they're afraid instead of fidgeting, and gets calmer the worse it gets
- 20 Keeps glancing at the empty chair, and answers a question nobody asked, before catching themselves

QUICK KEY

Rows 1, 6, 11, 14, 17, 18 *reveal* something — a lie, a fear, a past, a tell a sharp player can read. Rows 2, 3, 4, 8, 12, 16 are pure *texture* — they make the NPC stick without meaning anything. Rows 19 and 20 run *unsettling* — use them on the NPC you want the party to distrust before they know why. Roll twice for a person, not a prop: a tic that reveals plus a tic that's just them.

6. WHAT THIS NPC ACTUALLY WANTS

Roll the moment a conversation gets interesting and you realize you never decided what the NPC across the table is really after.

Every NPC walks into a scene wanting something the party can't see on their face. Pin that down and the conversation steers itself — they'll dodge, push, flatter, or stall, and the players will feel a current under the words without knowing the source. This is the want *right now*, in this room, not the grand life goal. Read the bold part as the pressure they're putting on the scene; keep the dash for what it costs them if the party figures it out.

D20 WHAT THEY ACTUALLY WANT...

- 1 **To find out how much the party already knows** — every question they ask is the real conversation; yours is the cover
- 2 **To be talked out of something they've already decided** — they want permission, not advice
- 3 **To stall until someone else arrives** — the clock is the plan; the chat is the wait
- 4 **To get one specific name out of the party** without letting on that the name is all they came for
- 5 **To be seen as more important than they are** — flatter them and they'll give you the keep
- 6 **To confess, badly, to the wrong people** — the guilt is leaking and they can't stop the seam
- 7 **To sell the party something** they don't yet know they need, and make it feel like their idea
- 8 **To borrow the party's reputation** — to be seen with them, so others draw the wrong conclusion
- 9 **To get the party to leave** without making it obvious they want them gone
- 10 **To test whether the party can be bought** — the offer is real, the price is the information
- 11 **To apologize** to someone in the party who doesn't remember the wrong
- 12 **To pass a message** they're too scared to deliver straight, buried in small talk
- 13 **To keep the party here**, in this room, away from where the real thing is happening
- 14 **To find out if they're suspected yet** — and they'll overplay the innocence to check
- 15 **To recruit one party member** quietly, and split them from the rest
- 16 **To settle an old score** the party doesn't know they're standing in the middle of
- 17 **To be reassured** that the terrible thing they did was the only choice
- 18 **To get a look at one thing the party is carrying** without asking to see it
- 19 **To trade up** — they've got better information for sale than the party came for, if the party proves worth it
- 20 **Nothing from the party at all** — they're here for someone else in the room, and the party is furniture

ROLL TWICE & COMBINE

Roll twice for a two-faced scene: the want they'll admit to (the first roll) and the want driving them under it (the second). Someone "stalling until backup arrives" who *also* "wants to be talked out of it" is a scene that can break either way — and the party's choices decide which.

7. WHY THE TOWN'S ON EDGE

Roll when the party rides into a place you didn't fully prep and the locals are clearly bracing for something — give the town a problem before the party even dismounts.

A town with nothing wrong is a town with nothing to do. The fix is to decide, before the party's boots hit the dirt, what's got the place wound tight — the thing everyone's talking around, the reason doors shut a little faster after dark. Each row is local tension the party can walk straight into. The bold part is what they'll notice; the dash is what's actually underneath, for you.

D20 THE TOWN IS ON EDGE BECAUSE...

- 1 **People have been going missing, one a week, always at night** — and the count is off by one; someone's hiding a body the party could find
- 2 **A stranger arrived three days ago and hasn't left their room** — the innkeeper's too frightened to ask them to
- 3 **The well's gone bad and nobody will say why** — the body in it belongs to someone important
- 4 **A festival's tomorrow and everyone's pretending to be excited** — the thing the festival is really for is the part they won't explain
- 5 **The militia's gone, marched out a week ago, and hasn't sent word** — the town is undefended and knows it
- 6 **Two families are one insult away from open blood** — and both are sizing up the party as hired muscle
- 7 **A debt's coming due and the collector isn't human** — the whole town's been paying into a pot that won't be enough
- 8 **Children won't go near the old mill anymore** — and the adults have started listening to why
- 9 **The priest stopped giving sermons a month ago** — and still takes the offerings, still locks the temple at night
- 10 **Livestock are dying in a pattern**, a straight line pointing at one house on the edge of town
- 11 **A hanging's scheduled for dawn and half the town thinks the prisoner's innocent** — the other half knows he is
- 12 **Strangers' faces are showing up on the wanted board faster than crimes are happening** — someone profits from arrests
- 13 **The mayor hasn't been seen in public in weeks** — the orders still come, signed, in handwriting that's changed
- 14 **A fire took the granary and the town's rationing** — and the fire started in the one building that was insured
- 15 **Every dog in town started barking at the same hour two nights ago and won't stop at that hour since**
- 16 **The road in and the road out have both had "accidents"** — the party may be the last travelers through for a while
- 17 **A wedding's off, violently, and both halves of the town took sides** — the bride knows something the groom's family wants buried
- 18 **The graveyard's short a few graves** — freshly empty, and nobody's admitting to a reburial
- 19 **A tax collector's overdue and a worse one is rumored to be coming instead** — the town's deciding whether to pay or run
- 20 **Nothing's wrong, loudly** — the town is too clean, too friendly, too quick to suggest the party move along by morning

QUICK KEY

Rows 1, 8, 10, 15, 18 run *eerie* — something's hunting or worse. Rows 6, 11, 17 are *human* tension the party can take a side in. Rows 5, 7, 14, 16, 19 are *pressure from outside* the party can shoulder or dodge. Roll twice and combine for a town with a fault line: the visible crisis (first roll) and the quieter rot under it (second) that explains why nobody's fixed the first.



AND THE D100 YOU ALREADY HAVE

What the Villain Is Doing Right Now — the centerpiece of this kit, in your welcome email. Roll it between sessions so your antagonist has a life the party hasn't earned access to yet, and the world keeps moving while the heroes sleep.



IF THIS IS USEFUL, THE REST IS TOO

The Field Kit is yours, free, for as long as you're subscribed. Print it, share it, scrawl on it.

If it earns a spot on your desk, here's what else lands in your inbox: **The Weekly One-Shot** — a complete, ready-to-run adventure every week. Villain with a reason. A real choice for the players. The boxed text written, the stat blocks sorted, the twist already built. Open it Thursday, run it Friday. That's the paid tier, and it exists for the same reason this kit does: so the silence at the table is yours to fill on purpose, not to scramble through.

No pressure. The tables work either way. See you at the table.



Original content © Long Island Dungeon Master. System-agnostic; compatible with fifth edition and other d20 fantasy games. No mechanics derived from any publisher's Product Identity. Free to use at your table — a quiet thank-you if you share it.